FIGURE 11.1 Nick Cave's Heard, 2016, in Sydney.

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Unit 4 ART AS ALTERNATE

In Unit 4, students continue and build on their focus, knowledge and art practice from Unit 3. They refine their expression and personal aesthetic by applying skills associated with creative thinking. Students resolve their body of work through the concept 'art as alternate' as they imagine, generate and apply new ideas and links. Through the pursuit of an individualised response, they challenge their approaches to identify alternatives and opportunities for innovation.

Students foreground the contemporary context to develop new meanings through a lens of 21st-century art ideas and issues. They simultaneously select from the personal, cultural and formal contexts to examine and compare visual language, expression and the communication of multiple meanings in various art forms.

Students use the inquiry learning model to resolve their body of work. They challenge their own art-making practices by researching and developing new knowledge of and skills in materials, techniques, technologies and arts processes. They look for opportunities for focused experimentation and risk taking. They explore how new and multimodal technologies can alter and enhance their ideas. Students determine alternate representations or expansions of their ideas by reflecting on their work from Unit 3 and considering how exploiting existing approaches or applying new knowledge and skill may enrich meaning in their body of work.

Students consider the roles and interaction between artist and audience. As audience, students consider how alternate methods of display and exhibition, contemporary approaches with materials, and new technologies impact upon the sensory experience and engagement with art. As artists, students consider the role of art in the dialogue with audience. They evaluate how alternate approaches in a body of work can develop and expand the communication of meaning and fully realise artistic intentions.

UNIT OBJECTIVES

By the end of this unit, students will:

1. implement ideas and representations that challenge, extend and refine existing knowledge
2. apply literacy skills to communicate understanding of art practices and individualised ideas
3. analyse and interpret the impact of contemporary context on visual language, expression and meaning in artworks and art practices
4. evaluate influences to inform an alternate approach
5. justify new viewpoints and evolving ideas
6. experiment with familiar or alternate media to solve visual problems informed by research of contemporary art practice
7. create visual responses using knowledge and understanding of media to support alternate approaches
8. realise responses to communicate intended meaning.

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Chapter 11 CREATING ALTERNATE MEANINGS

FIGURE 11.2 Casey Chen, *Big Robot 3*, 2022, glazed porcelain, ceramic colourants, enamels and gold lustre; fired four times, 38 x 23 x 23 cm

In Unit 4, you will develop your idea using alternate approaches through the contemporary context. Consciously applying creative thinking strategies will be helpful in generating your divergent responses.

> Creativity begins with a foundation of knowledge, learning a discipline and mastering a way of thinking. You can learn to be creative by experimenting, exploring, questioning assumptions, using imagination and synthesising information. Learning to be creative is akin to learning a sport. It requires practice to develop the right muscles and a supportive environment in which to flourish.
>
> LINDA NAIMAN, CREATIVITY COACH

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11.1 Area of study: Developing

How do artists generate solutions to visual problems?

Artists generate solutions to visual problems in countless different ways. These include the implementation of creative thinking strategies and the application of divergent approaches.

Creative thinking

Creativity is the process of generating new ideas or knowledge. In Visual Art, we value creativity because it is the process we use to find original approaches, pathways and points of view that enrich both our making and responding. **Creative** thinking establishes a point of difference between your work and that of others. It helps you develop your **personal aesthetic**. In Unit 4, you should be aiming to express your ideas in an inventive way using your own evolved personal style. Creative thinking will assist this process.

creative resulting from originality of thought or expression; relating to or involving the use of the imagination or original ideas to create something; having good imagination or original ideas

personal aesthetic where the artist develops a particular style or expression that is individual and inventive; students take ownership of their own approaches and style even if these approaches or styles have been appropriated from or have seeds in other artists' work

Creative traits

Creativity is not a mysterious attribute (talent) that only some people can attain or are born with. On the contrary, everyone can consciously develop creative traits.

Creative people are:

- curious – you should ask questions often, be inquisitive, investigate and experiment with art materials, techniques, processes, concepts
- courageous – you should be willing to try things out and make mistakes because that's how learning occurs
- adventurous and open-minded – you should challenge your own perceptions and common beliefs, make connections between ideas, be a critical thinker, analyse, evaluate and interpret information
- observant – you should learn to observe details, analyse and record what you see
- persistent – you should do a little bit every day, practise, keep working through problems, don't give up
- reflective – you should reflect on your ideas, past achievements, and feedback; consider implications for current and future projects.

Strategies to improve creative thinking

> The creative act does not create something out of nothing; it combines, reshuffles and relates already existing but hitherto separate ideas, facts, frames of perception and associative contexts.
>
> ARTHUR KOESTLER, AUTHOR

There have been many books and blogs written about improving creativity. They provide activities for building your creative capacity by helping you make connections between ideas. For instance, you can access design thinking activities online through the State Library of Queensland's Curriculum Connect site. These will help you to learn techniques that will give you confidence to reconsider your art practice and develop possibilities by combining, changing or reapplying existing ideas.

INQUIRY LEARNING 11.1

Brain warm-up: 40 uses for an object

Challenge yourself to individually think of 40 different uses for an object such as a brick, ping-pong ball, shoe or paperclip, with a time limit of 10 minutes. Then compare your list with your classmates. Reflect on how your brain worked during this brainstorming session. If you practise this activity, it should improve your divergent thinking.

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INQUIRY LEARNING 11.2

Making connections exercise: Finding faces in unusual places

Facial pareidolia is the name of the phenomenon that causes us to see faces in inanimate objects like clouds, wallpaper, machinery and household appliances. Your challenge is to actively hunt for 10 faces, photograph them and share them with your classmates. This task forces you to make creative connections and be an observer. Observation is key to creativity.

Adapted from John Ingledew, 2016, *How to Have Great Ideas: A Guide to Creative Thinking*

INQUIRY LEARNING 11.3

Positive action: How might I?

Rephrase your task for Unit 4 into a 'how might I?' question. This reframes the problem and forces it into an opportunity for innovation rather than allowing you to dwell on negatives. For instance, 'how might I create a collaborative work using my existing focus?' Once you have a question that is suitable, brainstorm as many possible answers to it as you can. Resist the urge to edit your brainstorming; be courageous.

Adapted from '"How might we" questions', Stanford University online

FIGURE 11.3 An example of a face hiding in an inanimate object

FIGURE 11.4 Can you see the face in this old telephone?

Invite your peers and teachers to share your problem-solving. Sometimes other people see the obvious things that you miss yourself. There are useful online brainstorming and collaboration sites that you can use to generate solutions to your problem. Ask for, listen to and act on feedback from your peers and your teacher. Survey your classmates and seek their suggestions about ways to evolve your making. Listen thoughtfully and openly to the suggestions from your teacher and act on their feedback from Unit 3.

Being creative in your art-making practice takes conscious effort, but there is also evidence to suggest that allowing your mind to subconsciously work on the problem has great advantages. So, ideally, begin the creative process early enough to allow for unconscious idea development to occur. To foster this, go for walks, swim, do the dishes and get a good night's sleep. When you allow time and opportunities for your brain to digest the problem, you might find you have a 'eureka' moment that sparks your alternate making adventure.

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INQUIRY LEARNING 11.4

SCAMPER: A technique to encourage divergent thinking

Apply the SCAMPER technique to your body of work to come up with some potential divergent approaches. SCAMPER stands for substitute, combine, adapt, modify, put to another use, eliminate, reverse. Record your SCAMPER ideas and then share them with your classmates.

- *Substitute* – is there another medium you could use, or a different art-making process you could apply to create new meaning?
- *Combine* – add elements from someone or something else. Can you combine some of the elements you have with others to create a redefined problem? Can you bring together different people or skills to collaborate to help you achieve a divergent approach?
- *Adapt* – take your existing focus and shape it using contemporary approaches but through a new context. Could new meaning be expressed through a personal, formal or cultural context?
- *Modify* – rework the focus. Are there dimensions of your idea you can expand/reduce? How might you change the way your idea is perceived – shape, scale, look, feel? Can you apply other verbs – magnify, minimise, manipulate, multiply?
- *Put to another use* – use your original focus in a new way. How could audiences be involved as joint constructors of meaning in a version of your idea? Could you change the method of display?
- *Eliminate* – get rid of unnecessary elements, or streamline the core idea. What would happen if you took away parts of the idea; what would that look like and how would people react?
- *Reverse* – turn your idea around. How can you make it communicate your original intention by implementing opposites? Consider **parody**, irony, sarcasm, binaries, ***wabi-sabi***.

Adapted from 'Scamper', Innovation Portal website

parody a humorous imitation designed to ridicule

wabi-sabi Japanese aesthetic that values simplicity, incompleteness, imperfection, impermanence, irregularity and nature

11.2 Area of study: Researching

How do artists react to stimulus?

A stimulus is a catalyst that provokes us to act. Artists are provoked into responding to stimuli in countless ways. In your research into artists, it is important to investigate their motivation for making artwork. Often there will be an overarching issue, concept or inquiry question that continues to drive the artist. Katie Harris-MacLeod's contemporary art practice consistently investigates our connection to natural places, drawing on a field of knowledge known as **psychogeography**. Her other influences are her Scottish heritage and folklore, multigenerational narratives, femininity, loss and isolation. Harris-MacLeod is particularly drawn to nature, forests, isolated and remote landscapes. She innovatively and poetically responds to natural sites through her artworks. While her interest in these concepts is constant, her focus for different series of works evolves, allowing her to explore and produce a variety of divergent approaches to what is often an intense experience of a place.

psychogeography the influence or effect of a geographical environment on a person's emotions and behaviour. Artists often take this approach when they interact with a city or a specific site and its history. The term was first used by French philosopher Guy Debord in 1955.

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Sapworks is an ongoing project exploring the interwoven connectivities between bodies of human beings and bodies of trees focusing on the female body. It began during an Arts and Ecology residency at the Maroochy Bushland Botanic Gardens. Harris-MacLeod's intention in this project was to intricately study Bloodwood trees, and the sap that they excrete.

Mapping stressed Bloodwood trees across the Sunshine Coast region, she made artworks from their sap as a process of reconnecting to place and country.

The sap from the Bloodwood tree visually resembles blood, and when used as a drawing ink, as Harris-MacLeod has done, results in mark-making suggestive of corporeality, light shining through skin, veins and bodily interiors, wounds or surgery. The works resonate with viewers, causing visceral responses. The project has given her a way to understand experiences and trauma from her own past.

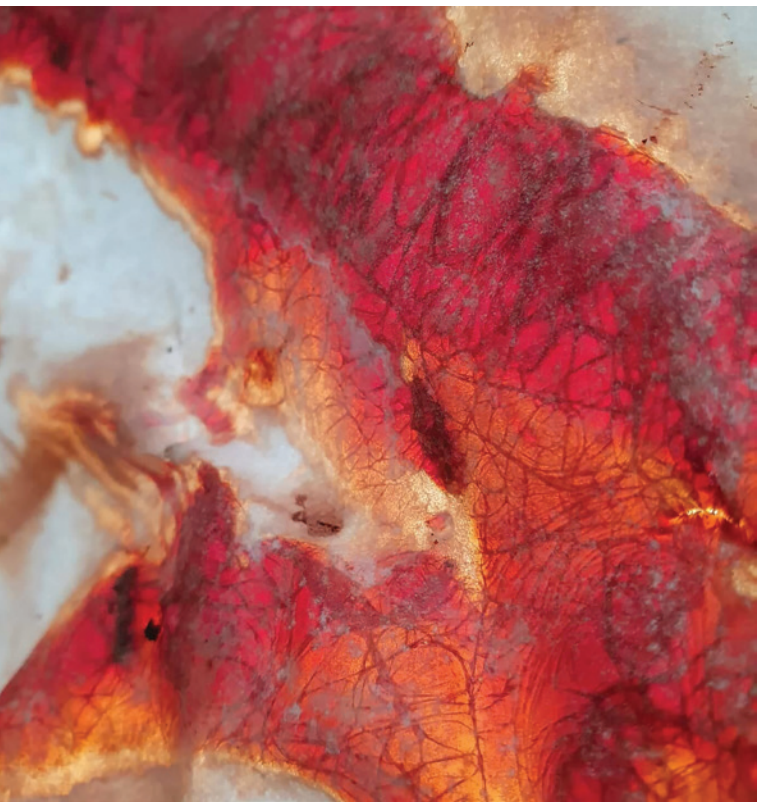

FIGURE 11.5 Katie Harris-MacLeod, *Sap Excretion – II*, 2020, bloodwood tree sap on paper, left under a bleeding bloodwood tree overnight in the rain – the sap exudes onto the paper, 29.7 x 42 cm

Harris-Macleod's innovative use of materials is also evident in her *Sleep Drawings* series. In an online interview Harris-MacLeod talks about how she is influenced by her Scottish heritage and the places she and her ancestors have lived. The Scottish environment has influenced her to find comfort in isolated environments, far away from people. She loves the sound of the wind and the vastness of the sky. Her Celtic/Gaelic culture, in which language and sense of place are interwoven, comes through in her use of poetry within her works as spoken word and also through the language of the marks she makes with her drawing media and implements. The artist describes the *Sleep Drawing* series as:

> **... inspired by lucid dream memories from sleeping on the edge of mountains; mind wanderings, dreams of creatures that live within the mountains, memories, myths, speaking rocks, lichens and mosses, mountain flowers, mist and distant echoes from the human world below.**
>
> *SLEEP DRAWINGS* AN EXHIBITION BY ARTIST KATIE HARRIS-MACLEOD. THE TIN SHED | PALMWOODS | 9TH – 30TH SEPTEMBER 2022

Figure 11.6 is an example of this body of work in which layer upon layer of marks and inks, some made from the materials in the landscape, are built up. Residue and memory of the layers below suggest memories and the passing of time.

Harris-MacLeod's practice includes performance and video as ways to respond to place and time and memory. Her grandmother's poem titled *Going Away*, has been read and recorded by Harris-MacLeod in a video work. The poem is accompanied by vision of slow-moving seaweeds as they are washed by gentle waves (see Figure 11.7). The calls of sea birds are heard and enhance the connection to place. The artist calls this work a 'Film Poem'.

Harris-MacLeod says of this work and her grandmother, "each time I read these words I understand her sense of longing more profoundly than before".

Harris-MacLeod provides us with an excellent model of how a body of work can include divergent approaches.

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FIGURE 11.6 Katie Harris-MacLeod, *Sleep Drawing (Mountain Dream Drawing),* 2022, copper oxide ink, cyanotype, tree sap, salt, lichen ink and acrylic ink on 300gsm watercolour paper, 29.7 x 42 cm

FIGURE 11.7 Katie Harris-MacLeod's video, *Going Away,* a poem by Janet M. MacLeod read by Katie Harris-MacLeod. Duration, 0.42 seconds, 2023. It can be viewed on the artist's website, https://cambridge.edu.au/redirect/10774

INQUIRY LEARNING 11.5

Katie Harris-MacLeod takes a psychogeographical approach to her art practice. Other artists who take or have taken this approach include Jonathan Jones, Megan Cope, Francis Alÿs, Jill Orr, Richard Long, Robert Smithson, James Turrell, Andy Goldsworthy, Christo and Jeanne-Claude, Ana Mendieta, Sophie Calle, Henri Cartier-Bresson, Vivian Maier and Asger Jorn.

With Katie Harris-MacLeod as a starting point, research the artists listed above to develop a reverse chronology showing how artists have approached psychogeographical influences in their art practice. Take care to indicate how the artists' practices and approaches are divergent to each other.

Identifying and researching divergent approaches

Your new, divergent approach to your body of work should aim to create alternate meaning through the knowledge, understanding and application of contemporary art processes. Contemporary artists approach their work in a myriad of different ways. Table 11.1 outlines some approaches you could take, but it is not exhaustive. Search broadly for artists to support your ideas and affirm your practice. Use art galleries, art museum sites or artists' own websites for research.

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TABLE 11.1 POSSIBLE WAYS TO CREATE ALTERNATE MEANING THROUGH THE KNOWLEDGE, UNDERSTANDING AND APPLICATION OF CONTEMPORARY ART PROCESSES

ALTERNATE APPROACHES	SYLLABUS SUGGESTED ARTISTS/ARTWORKS	OTHER CONTEMPORARY ARTISTS AND ARTWORKS TO CONSIDER
Adopting the opposing, contrary or polar point of view to communicate the same focus	• Tony Albert, *Sorry*, 2008 • Bindi Cole, *I Forgive You*, 2012	• Shaun Gladwell, *Double Balancing Act*, 2009–10
Questioning ideas and representations through the adoption of a different context	• Michael Zavros, *Spring/Fall* series, 2003–06 • Abdul Abdullah, *Coming to Terms* series, 2015	• Michael Zavros, *Ars Longa, Vita Brevis*, 2010; *Phoebe is Dead/McQueen*, 2010; *The Octopus*, 2014
Exploiting traditional materials and techniques in new or unexpected ways	• Ricky Swallow, *Killing Time*, 2003–04 • Owen Leong, *Infiltrator: Bone*, 2011	• Louise Weaver, *Guido Valdez (Vendetta for Love)*, 2006 • Fiona Hall, *Manuhiri (Travellers)*, 2014–15 • Casey Chen, *Big Robot* 3, 2022
Employing parody or irony to communicate meaning	• Daniel Boyd, *Treasure Island*, 2005 • Christian Thompson, *Museum of Others* series, 2016	• Cal Lane, *Doily Dumbbells*, 2020 • Mike Parr, *BDH*, 2016 • Richard Bell, *Worth Exploring?*, 2002
Changing scale, multiplying forms or changing the site or location of the work	• Ben Quilty, *Livvi*, 2009 • Simryn Gill, *Roadkill*, 2000 • Rosemary Laing, *Groundspeed*, 2001	• Robert MacPherson, *Boss Drovers*, 1996–2004 • Donna Marcus, *Burst*, 2017 • Kathleen Ryan, *Bad lemon (lichen)*, 2022
Making a single calculated change in materials, techniques, technologies or processes to alter the way audiences read, interpret and engage with the work	• Tsuyoshi Ozawa, *Vegetable weapon: Nishime, Fukushima*, 2011 • Hrafnhildur Arnardóttir/Shoplifter, *Planets* series, 2014–16 • Lucienne Rickard, *Extinction Studies*, 2019 • Fiona Hall, *Afraid Cascade*, 2020	• Claire Healey and Sean Cordeiro, *Par Avion*, 2011–12 • Li Hongbo, *Ocean of Flowers*, 2017 • Joachim Froese, *Turned Towards the Firmament*, 2022 • Diane Meyer, *time spent that might otherwise be forgotten*, ongoing project
Exploring the digital equivalent of analogue technologies	• William Kentridge, *I Am Not Me, the Horse Is Not Mine*, 2008	• Fiona McMonagle, *One Hundred Days at 7pm*, 2015 • Renata Buziak, *Centella asiatica... anti-inflammatory...*, 2015 • James Barth, *Gleaming, I'm shown*, 2021
Moving between the 2-dimensional plane, 3-dimensional form or time-based media	• Deborah Kelly, *Beastliness*, 2011	• Elizabeth Willing, *Tastes like Sunshine*, 2017 • Vernon Ah Kee, *a contented slave*, 2015 • Fiona Hall, *Wrong Way Time*, 2015 • Joan Ross, *Did you ask the river?*, 2019

(continued)

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Inviting others in as joint constructors of meaning	• Gosia Wlodarczak and Longin Sarnecki, *400*, 2010	• Imants Tillers and Michael Nelson Jagamara, *The Messenger*, 2014 • Ai Weiwei, *Sunflower Seeds*, 2010
Moving from high degrees of artist control and authorship of works to collaborative approaches that may require the relinquishing of some artist control	• Sophie Calle, *Take Care of Yourself*, 2009 • Hiromi Tango, *Art Magic: The Climbing Plant*, 2015 • Antony Gormley, *Field*, 1989–2003 • Alfredo and Isabel Aquilizan, *Inhabit*, 2012	• *The One Year Drawing Project*, 2005–07 • Marina Abramović, *Rhythm 0*, 1974
Using an AI tool and engineered prompts to suggest or determine the next phase of the body of work	• Sam Leach, *EV Helmet with Egret Crest*, 2018 • Jessie Hughes, *Soul of Sol – La Palma* • Georgie Pinn, *Ripple*, 2021	• Sougwen Chung, *Wave Studies*, 2021

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Casey Chen exploits the traditional techniques and forms of South-East Asian fine ceramic production through his wheel throwing and decorating of clay vessels. He unexpectedly juxtaposes images from pop culture, folklore and mythology onto the surfaces of the otherwise authentic-looking ceramic ware.

FIGURE 11.8 Casey Chen, *Big Robot 3*, 2022, glazed porcelain, ceramic colourants, enamels and gold lustre; fired four times, 38 x 23 x 23 cm

INQUIRY LEARNING 11.6

1. Read through the list of artists in Table 11.1. Choose three artists to explore further. Read about them, and analyse how they apply contemporary approaches in their practice.
2. Use mind mapping or brainstorming, either individually or as a group, to think of ways that you could apply one of these identified contemporary processes to your focus from Unit 3 that would result in a divergent approach.

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11.3 Area of study: Reflecting

How do artists consider ideas and information, media techniques and processes?

Reflection is essential to the inquiry learning model. As a vital component of the creative process, it forces you to stop and think or evaluate how you are proceeding in terms of producing a response to your inquiry question. This provides opportunities to consider various ways to enhance, evolve and refine your art-making and communication of meaning.

Reflecting on Unit 3

In Unit 4, you will use reflection initially to evaluate how well your artwork from Unit 3 has communicated your intended meaning. Surveying audiences, such as your classmates, is a good way to gauge how the audience understood and responded to your work. After you have collected their ideas, you need to collate their responses and evaluate them. Add this knowledge to the mix when developing your alternate approach.

Another useful exercise is to look carefully at your teacher's feedback on your IA1 and IA2. Write the feedback into your visual diary and analyse it. Evaluate how you can improve your art-making practice. Throughout this unit you should take responsibility for your art-making and use reflection as a key tool in your making process.

Reflecting as you go in Unit 4

When to reflect

Reflection needs to occur regularly during the art-making cycle. The best way to reflect is to make a regular time and develop a habit to do so. It could be at the end of a series of

INQUIRY LEARNING 11.7

Reflect on your own and others' body of work. In an informal discussion in a small group, give thoughtful feedback and suggestions to each other about how to implement alternate approaches.

Part 1

Answer the questions and use the prompts below to help you prepare and then explain your work to your group.

1. What knowledge did you engage with in Unit 3?
2. What focus did you explore?
3. What was your inquiry question?
4. What context did you work in?
5. What media, processes, technologies and materials did you work with?
6. Which key artists helped shape your ideas, and why?
7. Evaluate the success of your intended communication of meaning. What worked? What didn't work?
8. What would you do differently?
9. Did audiences understand/empathise/question/challenge/learn/react? How? Why?
10. What divergent approaches are you considering?

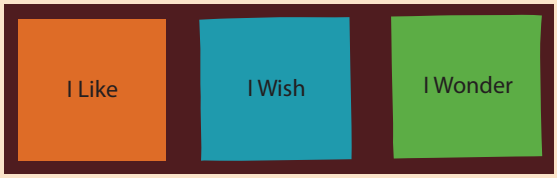

FIGURE 11.9 'I like, I wish, I wonder' is a strategy for providing constructive feedback to others.

Part 2

After hearing about your work, each of the other group members writes down on a sticky note an idea they like about your work – something they wish could have been done in the work – and a question: I wonder ... in response. These are given to you to stick in your book, and evaluate and reflect on.

Adapted from A. Kotahri, 'I like, I wish, I wonder', LinkedIn, 17 October 2013

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experiments, after a session of reading about an artist, at the end of each lesson, after each one-on-one consultation with your teacher or once a week.

You need to show you have reflected meaningfully on your art-making at each stage – in developing, in researching and in resolving. Key evidence will need to be gathered for your IA3 assessment submission.

How to reflect and what to reflect on

In Unit 4, you need to use reflection to evaluate your progress and justify your aesthetic decision-making and your viewpoint. Specifically, you need to ensure you reflect on:

- contemporary artists' uses of alternate approaches to enhance and communicate alternate meaning through innovative art practice and exploitation of audience expectations
- your own initial artworks in your body of work and the intention and success of meaning communicated
- ideas for alternate methods and/or approaches to expand communication of focus and meaning
- your own experiments with media, technology, processes and materials to create alternate approaches
- the impact of key contemporary artists from diverse practices, traditions, cultures and theories to develop and inspire alternate representations and meaning in your own body of work
- your individual art practice, justifying your choices and application of alternate approaches to explain how new viewpoints or interpretations are communicated
- you will need to justify your intended outcomes by having evidence of how you evaluated or weighed up the strengths, implications and limitations of your alternate approaches to the problem
- you will need to have evidence that you have evaluated the interrelationships of visual language and influences to demonstrate purposeful problem solving and choices.

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A strategy for reflecting

To make your reflection meaningful, try the *Stop, Evaluate, Document* strategy.

- *Stop:* Give yourself space and time to sit and look at your work, your experimentation, your research, your plans, your trials or whatever you have been working on at any stage.
- *Evaluate:* Assess how a small section of the project or the project as a whole is progressing and fits into your intentions. Ask yourself all or some of these questions and record your answers.
  - What was I trying to achieve by doing this (research new ideas, experiment with new materials)?
  - How was it successful in relation to the inquiry question (what has worked, what are the strengths, are there unexpected results that I can capitalise on)?
  - How could it be done differently (what were the limitations, acknowledge failure and learn from it, propose new experiments, solutions, options)?
  - How can I use it (how will it add meaning to my alternate approach)?
  - What did I learn from it (what are the implications for improving my approach, how did it affirm my pathway or challenge my thinking)?
  - How does it support my intentions and the communication of meaning (what are the implications for meaning-making, how will I use this knowledge to create new meaning in my artwork)?
  - How do/might audiences react to this (what unanticipated associations or readings does an audience bring to the work, how could I use this insight as an opportunity to develop new meaning, how could the audience be joint constructors of meaning or collaborators)?
  - How will I move forward from this point (what's next, based on this new knowledge, what changes do I need to make to my intentions or goals, if any; why)?
- *Document:* Keep a record of all reflection. This might be in a visual diary, a series of digital files, written or spoken, a website or a blog. Documentation shows your ability to make meaningful connections and informs the evolution and refining of your focus and making. It will inform the evolution

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of your thinking and the refinement of the resolved work. It will help you explain how new viewpoints or interpretations are communicated. It will be needed to help you to form your artist's statement and annotated illustration for your IA3.

INQUIRY LEARNING 11.8

Reflect on a range of contemporary art approaches to explore and consider alternate ideas as you construct new personalised meaning. (Refer to Table 11.1.)

1. Consider the list of alternate contemporary approaches in the left-hand column and choose five that appeal to you.
2. For each, brainstorm a series of experiments that would propel your divergent art-making. For example, if you have worked in two-dimensional media in Unit 3, you might plan a series of experiments using three-dimensional processes such as plaster casting, modelling with plasticine, building with clay or carving in wood.
3. Use the Stop, Evaluate, Document strategy or create your own series of questions to help you reflect on these ideas and then answer them. For instance:
   - What knowledge do I have of these materials?
   - What do I need to learn about them?
   - How could I construct new meaning with these divergent approaches?
   - What aspects of my focus (knowledge, subject matter, meaning, use of visual language and expression) could I apply to this approach?
4. Document and save your reflection. Your reflection can be written, spoken and may even be developed into thumbnail drawings.

11.4 Area of study: Resolving

How do artists communicate individual ideas as visual, written or spoken responses?

By the end of Unit 4, you need to resolve your body of work and are expected to realise and communicate your intentions in both your visual and written responses. This is when everything comes together.

In your written work, you need to apply literacy knowledge and skills, visual art terminology, language conventions, referencing conventions and critical literacies. Refer to the syllabus for a more detailed explanation of the subject matter.

At this point in your art-making, your personal aesthetic will have evolved through your research and understanding of contemporary artists, art theories and knowledge of art media and processes. You need to use this knowledge to guide the application of your divergent approaches to achieve refinement of your art-making.

In resolving your work, you need to communicate your intended meaning through its display or virtual display and you need to consider and show understanding of how audiences will experience the work.

The role of the audience

Artist's Statement

All in all, the creative act is not performed by the artist alone; the spectator brings the work in contact with the external world by deciphering and interpreting its inner qualifications and thus adds his contribution to the creative act.

MARCEL DUCHAMP

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The **Dadaists**, a modernist movement with which Marcel Duchamp is associated, as early as 1916 enticed the audiences of their bizarre cabarets to interact by pelting the performers with food, thus reinforcing the anti-art nature of their ideas.

Yet it wasn't until the latter part of the 20th century that artists and theorists began to acknowledge the important role the audience plays in the creation of meaning within artworks. **Fluxus** artists, such as Yoko Ono, began including the audience as participants in the 1960s. Ono's *Cut Piece* is a good example of an early Fluxus work that required audience participation to be fully resolved. In this work, she sat fully clothed and vulnerable, on a stage with a pair of scissors, and invited the audience to cut pieces of her clothing from her. She provided instructions for the participants to follow. This work made a statement about feminine passivity and vulnerability. There is video footage of this work available online. If you watch it, you will see that it becomes increasingly difficult to view as the audience becomes increasingly aggressive. While Ono gives up artistic control, she nonetheless achieves a genuine response from the audience. In 2003, she reprised this work as a reaction against the pervasive, global climate of fear caused by the terrorist attacks in the United States on 11 September 2001. In this work, she asked participants to send a piece of her clothing to a loved one as a gesture of world peace.

Dada a modernist art movement originating in Zurich in 1916. It was a reaction against the horror of World War I and its devastating impact. The Dadaists created bizarre and satirical performances and happenings at the Cabaret Voltaire in Zurich and in other European cities

Fluxus somewhat founded on the ideas of Dada, but was a network of artists with an attitude of taking chances and trying new things, rather than a movement. They were against the commercialism of art and its elitist status. They used everyday materials and alternate venues to galleries. It was based in New York.

In contemporary art practice, it is acknowledged that audiences bring their own experiences and knowledge to their perception and understanding of artwork. The implication for artists is that they need to consider or anticipate the possible readings inherent in their work. Your intended meaning may not be read by the audience the way you expect. In the research, development and reflection of your project, you need to be analysing and evaluating how to manipulate visual language and expression effectively to elicit your desired response from your audience.

FIGURE 11.10 Hugo Ball (1886–1927), Dadaist writer and poet, wearing a Cubist suit made by himself and Marcel Janco for reciting his poems at Cabaret Voltaire, Zurich, 23 June 1916

FIGURE 11.11 Sean Lennon snips off a piece of his mother's clothes with a pair of scissors, 15 September 2003, at the Ranelagh theatre in Paris during *Cut Piece* – an avant-garde performance staged by Yoko Ono 40 years after her work was first put on in a Japanese theatre.

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Alternate display opportunities

Contemporary artists are not restricted to traditional display conventions. You should seek to display your resolved work in a way that contributes to the communication of meaning and enhances engagement for the audience. The physical or virtual display of the work should be guided by the characteristics of the contemporary context, which are explained in chapter 1.

If your idea for display of your body of work is not actually physically achievable, you are required to provide documentation of the intended display through digital or virtual forums.

Alternate contemporary innovative display could include, but is not limited, to:

- audience participation – Yoko Ono, *Cut Piece*, 1964, Ken + Julia Yonetani, *Fumie Tiles*, 2003; Super Critical Mass, *Bell Field*, 2014
- collaborative performance – Nick Cave, *Heard*, 2016 (Figure 11.12)
- immersive experience – Yayoi Kusama, *Soul under the Moon*, 2002; Olafur Eliasson, *Riverbed*, 2014; Anthony McCall, *Crossing*, 2016
- working directly onto gallery walls – Dale Harding, *Wall Composition in Reckitt's Blue*, 2017; Elizabeth Willing, *Dark*, 2017, Robert Andrew, *A connective reveal—nainmurra guuruburrii dhaura*, 2022 (Figure 11.13)
- digital projection – onto walls, floors, other objects, exterior environments, multichannel – Pipilotti Rist, *Your Room Opposite the Opera*, 2017; Bill Viola, *Fire Woman*, 2005; Tony Oursler, *Incubator*, 2003; Shaun Gladwell, *Double Balancing Act*, 2009–10; Craig Walsh, *Murujuga in the Pilbara*, 2012–13, Maeve Baker, *Do Your Chores, Try Not To Think Too Much, And Repeat*, 7 Dec–31 Jan 2021 (Figure 11.14)
- display in exterior environment – Fiona Hall, *The Barbarians at the Gate*, 2010.

FIGURE 11.12 Nick Cave's *Heard,* 2016, in Sydney. Cave constructs 'sound suits' that are worn in performances by dancers who collaborate with Cave to animate the costumes.

FIGURE 11.13 Robert Andrew, *A connective reveal—nainmurra guuruburrii dhaura*, 2022, National Gallery of Australia. Layers of ochres were directly applied to the gallery wall and are slowly revealed using a device programmed to spray water at the wall. This progressively reveals the text, written in a local language or the artist's Yawuru language. The display of the work is integral to the artist's intentions which we can interpret through the contemporary context because Andrew comments on the use of language (and denial of language) as a tool for colonising.

FIGURE 11.14 Maeve Baker, *Do Your Chores, Try Not To Think Too Much, And Repeat,* 7 Dec–31 Jan 2021, façade projection onto the IMA Belltower of Brisbane's Judith Wright Arts Centre. The contemporary artwork expresses the emotional impact of living in lockdown during the COVID-19 pandemic. The work is a personal response yet it resonates with the community at large because everyone experienced those emotions. The work, displayed in such a public place, allows for maximum access for the audience. The size of the projection emphasises the enormity of the boredom and anxiety felt by everyone living through the pandemic.

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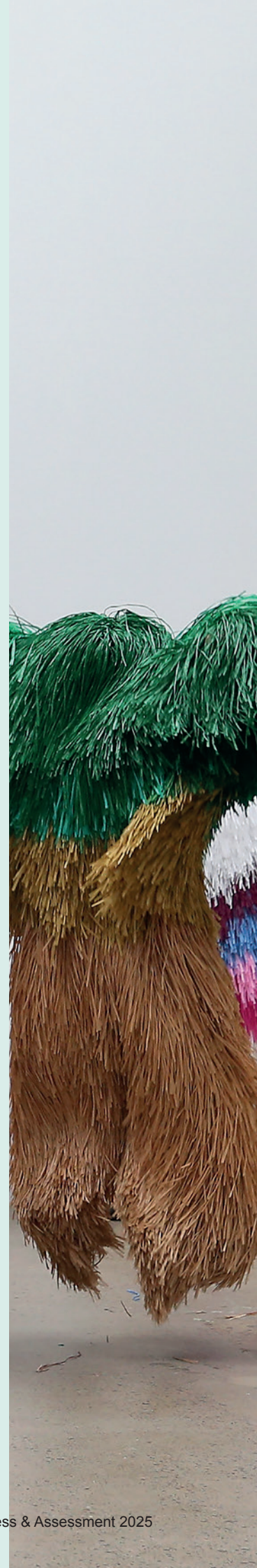
Chapter summary

- Creativity is not a mysterious attribute. Everyone can consciously develop creative traits, so apply yourself to developing yours.
- Divergent solutions can be arrived at by practising creative thinking and developing possibilities through the combination, changing or reapplication of existing ideas.
- Invite others to share your problem-solving. Sometimes others see the things you miss.
- Begin the creative process early enough to allow for unconscious idea development to occur, to capitalise on serendipitous opportunities and to provide time for reflection and feedback.
- Artists respond to stimuli in countless ways, so research broadly.
- Your new approach to your body of work should aim to create alternate meaning through the knowledge, understanding and application of contemporary art processes.
- Reflect meaningfully on your art-making and responding at each stage of the project – in developing, researching and resolving.
- Use your personal aesthetic to guide the way you apply your divergent approach to the body of work.
- Audiences bring their own meaning when they respond to visual art, so ensure you consider audience engagement and their experience in the resolution of your body of work.
- Consider ways to enhance meaning and engage audiences through knowledge of contemporary context and alternate display opportunities.



Review questions

1. Identify the meaning of divergent pathways in artistic practice.
2. Evaluate some contemporary approaches to art-making.
3. Analyse the value of reflection in an inquiry-driven artistic practice.
4. Create and justify your own viewpoint on the importance of creativity in artistic practice.

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